



AP

DELHI | The Final Gambit

In a measure of the massive military pressure the Sri Lankan military is applying on the Tamil Tigers, the encircled LTTE has been forced to play its last card—Kumaran Pathmanathan alias Selvarajah Pathmanathan, the head of their global arms procurement network. The Tigers have appointed Pathmanathan, 54, as the head of their international diplomatic relations in a desperate attempt to secure peace and save the senior Tiger leadership from annihilation. "We are not surprised by this move, it just shows that the LTTE is short of leaders," says Brigadier Udaya Nannayakara, Sri Lankan army spokesperson. 'KP', as he is known, is the most important man in the LTTE after V. Prabhakaran and reports only to the Tiger chief. Known for his phenomenal fund-raising and arms purchasing abilities, KP juggled an estimated \$70 million (Rs 350 crore) every year, most of it vacuumed from the overseas Tamil diaspora, and used it to buy arms from Cambodia and Afghanistan. For nearly two decades, KP was the elusive shadowy South-east Asia-based figure who supplied arms to the LTTE, using their fleet of Sea Pigeon freighters. He operated behind a smokescreen of aliases and multiple passports and was first named by the Jain Commission which probed Rajiv Gandhi's assassination. Later the subject of an Interpol red corner alert, KP was nabbed in Malaysia last year but slipped away. This was one of several escapes of a man whom the Tigers hope can now use his international contacts to save them from extinction.

LTTE CADRES;
PATHMANATHAN
(INSET)

by Sandeep Unnithan

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million dollars (Rs 350 cr) is what Pathmanathan is believed to have raised for the LTTE each year from the Tamil diaspora to buy arms.